

# The Boston Globe

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‘The public has sacrificed a lot over the last three decades to get us here.’

CHRIS KENNEDY, former assistant commissioner of what is now the state Department of Fish and Game



## LOOKING FOR BALANCE ON DUXBURY BEACH

Successful bird protections can mean even more limited access



PHOTOS BY CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

Top: Peter Tucci, 10, played ball with his family at First Crossover at Duxbury Beach. Above: A pair of piping plovers walked the shore at Duxbury Beach.

By Billy Baker  
GLOBE STAFF

DUXBURY — As Andrew Marshall drives up to the barrier on Duxbury Beach, he shakes his head. In front of him is miles of open sand. For generations, the quintessential image of summer in this town was to see the shoreline of this 7.5-mile barrier beach lined with vehicles, tailgates down, surrounded by beach chairs and coolers, maybe a campfire at sunset. “Closed for least terns,” he says with a practiced frustration. The story in Duxbury is one that’s happening up and down the Massachusetts coast, from Plum Island to Martha’s Vineyard, and it’s a Catch-22. Beach access gets restricted to protect nesting sites for least terns and piping plovers, which leads to a growth in their populations. That then leads to more stretches of beach being shut down each summer to protect the increasing number of nests. While many conservationists rightly celebrate the recovery of the endangered shorebirds, which began decades ago with the implementation of strict beach guidelines, those measures have restricted recreation op-

BIRDS, Page A10

## High housing prices help solidify Mass. wealth gap

Homeowners build equity while renters face soaring costs with no way to save

By Andrew Brinker  
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts’ ever-rising house prices make life difficult. But a new landmark report from the Federal Reserve Bank of Boston shows this state’s lofty housing prices have another pernicious effect: maintaining, or perhaps even deepening, the state’s stubborn racial wealth gap. The report, released Wednesday, updated an infamous 2015 study that found US-born Black Bostonians had a median net wealth of just \$8. The latest report finds homeowners in Massachusetts — the majority of whom are white — have vastly more wealth than renters, largely because of the equity in their properties, that in turn fuels the wealth gap. “We know that homeownership is still the primary vehicle for building generational wealth in this country,” said Symone Crawford, executive director of the Massachusetts Affordable Housing Alliance. “Access to it has never been equal. And the fact that we have some of the highest home prices in the country, and that those prices are still rising, is only compounding that gap, no matter how much we talk about closing it.” Homeownership has long been the primary key to wealth building in the United States. The relative accessibility of long-term mortgages allows buyers to pay for valuable assets over the course of decades. But in what has become a vicious cycle for tenants, many can’t save for a down payment on a house because

of soaring rent prices, and yet they can’t build wealth through home equity because their housing expenses are effectively money they will not get back. In fact, more than 60 percent of renters here don’t have the money for even the upfront costs to move into a new apartment, let alone a down payment on a house. The result is a gap that shows the median net wealth for homeowners in Massachusetts is \$790,500, and just \$1,500 for renters, the study found. Black and Hispanic families own their homes at far lower rates than

HOUSING, Page A6

## Lawrence mayor is charged with fraud

US says he used COVID funds for campaign, debts

By Sean Cotter  
GLOBE STAFF

By mid-2021, hundreds of thousands of dollars in personal bills were coming due for Brian DePeña, and, according to authorities, his campaign for Lawrence mayor needed money, too. But DePeña, according to federal prosecutors, turned to a source of cash that he had access to thanks to his tire dealership: low-interest, high-dollar loans the federal government was offering to businesses to help dig out from the coronavirus pandemic. His requests grew to more than \$1.6 million, according to court documents. But instead of putting the money into his business as he was required to, authorities say DePeña used it to pay down personal debts and also steered \$90,000 to his campaign committee. And indeed, he won the race for mayor in 2021 and cleared many personal debts, the documents state. But around dawn on Friday, half a decade later, FBI agents arrested him at his home. DePeña, still the sitting mayor of Lawrence, appeared in federal court in Boston Friday afternoon facing felony charges of wire fraud and money laundering. After the brief hearing, he was released on conditions including that he stay in Massachusetts, surrender his passport, and desist from applying for loans without the gov-

MAYOR, Page A6

## T to pay official \$500,000 after Eng pulled hair

Woman will also resign from role at agency

By Diti Kohli  
GLOBE STAFF

The MBTA will pay nearly \$500,000 to the employee whose hair general manager Phil Eng admitted to — and apologized for — pulling at a 2024 dinner, according to a settlement agreement released Friday by the transit agency. The deal between the T and Gabrielle Mondestin, the T’s chief communications officer since 2023, will end a strange saga in which Eng repeatedly acknowledged that his actions nearly two years ago toward Mondestin, who is Black, were “insensitive.” For months, the T has disclosed very little about the situation, from the steps it took to investigate the incident or whether Eng himself was involved in any negotiations with Mondestin. Mondestin will resign from the agency on Sept. 18 with a \$495,000 settlement. Of the total, \$240,000 covers a one-time supplemental wage payment; the remaining \$255,000 is for damages or attorneys’ fees. The agreement does not include an admission of wrongdoing by Eng, who also serves as the

ENG, Page A10



Win win

Saturday: Sunny and nice. High: 77-82. Low: 61-66.

Sunday: Clouds arrive later. High: 77-82. Low: 64-69.

High tide: 1:28 a.m. 1:58 p.m. Sunrise: 5:51 Sunset: 7:45

Comics and Weather, D4-5. Obituaries, C9.

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Luigi Mangione pleaded guilty to federal stalking charges in the killing of UnitedHealthcare CEO Brian Thompson, admitting that he trailed the executive and gunned him down in 2024. A2.

Jason Arday has died, his family said. The former Cambridge University scholar’s remarkable rise to stardom was followed by a recent rapid fall from grace. A3.

Massachusetts Commissioner of Higher Education Noe Ortega will step down in September following a four-year tenure. B1.

The Red Sox office staff is relocating from Fenway Park in a move to consolidate space with Fenway Sports Group. D1.

## Young athletes feel politics’ sting

### At Trump’s Patriot Games: competition, camaraderie, and criticism

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru  
GLOBE STAFF

GENEVA, Ohio — Jonah Beauregard knew when he was selected to represent Massachusetts that the Patriot Games would be controversial. The three-day athletic competition, featuring one boy and one girl representing each state, some US territories and tribal nations, was the latest flashy celebration of America’s 250th birthday touted by President Trump. Beauregard, a 17-year-old from Worcester attending the Bancroft School, told the Globe he anticipated backlash “because it’s Trump. He’s the one that made it. I feel like he’s definitely a person that people don’t like.” What Beauregard had a harder time understanding was why the athletes themselves, all between the ages of 14 and 17, received so much criticism for participating. “We can’t vote. We can’t do anything in our power to do anything to help it,” said Beauregard, who applied for the games at the suggestion of a friend. At the Patriot Games, about 120 teenagers found them-

PATRIOT GAMES, Page A7



JIM WATSON/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

President Trump joined the Patriot Games competitors during a ceremony at the finals on Tuesday.